Institution: Staatliche Antikensammlungen
Registration Number: 8729
Beazley Archive Number: 310403 (*ABV* 145.21)
Fabric: Athenian, black-figure
Shape: Kylix (drinking cup), Type A ("eye-cup")
Attribution: Exekias (Signed as potter; painting attributed by style)
Date: c. 540- 530 BCE
Dimensions: H. 12.8cm; D. 30.4cm
Findspot: Italy, Etruria, Vulci
Provenance: Acquired from the Canino Collection

Fabric, Technique, Shape & Condition

Attic black-figure eye-cup of Type A. An early and formative example of this shape.[1] The vessel is characterised by a lipless bowl with a continuous, flowing profile, a short stem, and horizontal handles.[2]

The interior Picture-space has been coated with a fine lustrous coral-red slip, an unusual technique occasionally employed in both black- and red-figure painting.[3] Figures are rendered in black glaze against the coral-red ground in the interior, and against the reserved ground on the exterior. Added white is used for the sail, armour, selected details of the dolphins and rigging. The cup has been assembled from numerous fragments and a few splinters, with some gaps restored; the face of Dionysus has been restored with tempera.[4]

Fig. 1. Exekias (potter and painter), *Kylix (Dionysus Cup)*, ca. 540–530 BCE. Terracotta; black-figure with coral-red slip, H. 12.8 cm, Diam. 30.4 cm. Staatliche Antikensammlungen, Munich, inv. 8729. Composite image: exterior, Sides A and B. Wikimedia Commons.

Iconography Exterior is organised into four distinct zones: two eye-areas and two handle-areas (Fig. 1). On each half of the exterior a pair of large apotropaic eyes flanks a stylised nose, a standard feature of type A eye-cups. The primary figural scenes are unusually displaced to the handle-areas. On each handle-zone, warriors fight over a fallen figure. The composition on both sides is closely related, with advancing hoplites

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[1] J. D. BEAZLEY. "EXEKIAS." In *The Development of the Attic Black-Figure, Revised Edition*, DGO-Digital original, 1. University of California Press, 2023.

[2] Classical Art Research Centre, University of Oxford. "Cups and Other Drinking Vessels." *Introduction to Greek Pottery: Shapes*. Accessed April 1, 2026. https://www.carc.ox.ac.uk/carc/resources/Introduction-to-Greek-Pottery/Shapes/Cups-and-other-drinking-vessels.

[3] Fellmann, Berthold. *Corpus Vasorum Antiquorum: München, Antikensammlungen*, fasc. 13. CVA Deutschland, fasc. 77. Munich: C.H. Beck, 2004, 13–19, Beilage 1.1, pls. 1.1–2, 2.1–3, 3.1–2, 4.1, 1.1, 2.1–2.

[4] Ibid.

converging on the body beneath the handle. These scenes have been tentatively associated with the struggle for the body of Patroclus.[5]

The tondo forms the compositional and iconographic focus of this vessel (Fig. 2). It depicts the sea voyage of Dionysus on a coral-red ground, evoking the "wine-coloured sea". The ship is rendered with careful detail: the bow takes the form of a stylised animal head, and the stern terminates in a swan's head ornament. A tall grapevine grows from the mast, its branches heavy with seven clusters of grapes.

Dionysus reclines within the ship in the pose of a symposiast, turned to the left, holding a rhyton and wreathed in ivy. Dolphins surround the vessel.

The narrative on the central tondo has frequently been interpreted as the story of the Tyrrhenian pirates recounted in the Homeric Hymns to Dionysus.[6] However, no specific narrative elements of the myth are represented (no hint of an attack on Dionysus; metamorphoses of pirate figures absent).[7] The image may be better understood within a broader Dionysiac and sympotic framework, in which dolphins function as emblems of transformation associated with the god and the experience of the symposium.[8]

Fig. 2. Exekias (potter and painter), *Kylix (Dionysus Cup)* (detail: interior tondo, Dionysus sailing among dolphins), ca. 540–530 BCE. Terracotta; black-figure with coral-red slip. Staatliche Antikensammlungen, Munich, inv. 8729. Wikimedia Commons.

Attribution & Dating The cup is signed on the reserved foot profile and reads "ECHSEKIAS EPOESE" ("Exekias made me"), identifying Exekias as the potter.[9] The attribution of the painting to Exekias rests on stylistic comparison with his double-signed works.[10] CVA plates place this cup among the later works of the master, and identifies the cup as one of the earliest known examples of type A kylikes. The use of coral-red slip, the exceptionally large tondo filling almost the entirety of the interior, and the displacement of the compositional focus to the handle- areas rather than the eye-areas all mark this cup as a work of formal and technical innovation without close parallel. A date around 540-530 BCE is appropriate.

[5] J. D. BEAZLEY. "EXEKIAS.", 2023.

[6] Beaulieu, Marie-Claire. "Dionysus and the Sea." In *The Sea in the Greek Imagination*. University of Pennsylvania Press, Inc, 2015. https://doi.org/10.9783/9780812291964-008.

[7] Ibid.

[8] Ibid.

[9] Beazley, J.D. Attic Black-Figure Vase-Painters. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1956, 146.21; Fellmann, Berthold. Corpus Vasorum Antiquorum: München, Antikensammlungen, fasc. 13. CVA Deutschland, fasc. 77. Munich: C.H. Beck, 2004, 13–19.

[10] J. D. BEAZLEY. "EXEKIAS.", 2023.

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Bibi Saint-Pol. *Dionysos in a Ship, Sailing among Dolphins. Attic Black-Figure Kylix, ca. 530 BC. From Vulci. Interior of the Dionysus Cup by Exekias.* Photograph, 2007. Wikimedia Commons. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Exekias_Dionysos_Staatliche_Antikensammlungen_2044.jpg.

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Marcus Cyron. *Outside of the Dionysus Cup by Exekias. Staatliche Antikensammlungen, Munich, inv. 8729.* Photograph. Wikimedia Commons. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/Category:Dionysos_Cup_(Exekias).